

Cuba



The largest island in the Caribbean, Cuba has fertile lowlands set between three large mountainous regions. Sugar, rice, tobacco, and coffee are grown on the lowlands, and chromium and nickel are mined. Formerly a Spanish colony, Cuba has been a communist state since 1959. Hostile politics caused the USA to impose a trade embargo, which has disabled Cuba's economy and kept it agricultural.

Sugar

With an annual production of 50,000,000 tonnes (55,000,000 tons), sugar-cane is Cuba's largest crop. It is grown around Havana and processed in the city's factories. Cuba is one of the world's largest producers but suffered a decline in the 1990s following the collapse of one of its main customers, the Soviet Union.



Communism

The only communist state in the Caribbean, Cuba is led by Fidel Castro (b. 1926), who led the revolution in 1959. Under Castro, and with Soviet help, Cuba made considerable social and economic progress, although living standards suffered with the breakup of Soviet communism in 1991. US policies remain hostile.



Havana

Situated in a natural harbour, Cuba's chief port and capital, Havana, was founded by the Spanish in 1515. Its old town has many ancient buildings and cobbled streets. There are no shanty towns here, unlike many capitals in the region, but of its 2,328,000 people, half live in sub-standard houses.

CUBA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Havana
AREA	110,860 sq km (42,803 sq miles)
POPULATION	11,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Spanish
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Peso



Cigars

Cuba's fertile soil and warm climate are ideal for growing high-quality tobacco. Havana cigars are popular all over the world and are made from a blend of at least five different types of tobacco. Cigars are still rolled by hand at long wooden tables.



Bahamas



Located to the northeast of Cuba, the Bahamas extend south for about 965 km (600 miles). Of the 3,000 coral islands and islets, only 30 are inhabited. Most of the people are black, but on Spanish Wells island, there are around 1,200 white descendants of Puritan settlers. Tourism, fishing, and financial services flourish on the islands.



Festival

Music and dancing are everywhere in the Caribbean, but especially so at the Junkanoo Festival on the Bahamas islands. Held at the end of every year, Junkanoo is a lively celebration with street dancing, music, and colourful parades where people wear wild costumes and blow whistles. The festival has roots in the celebrations of a slave leader called John Canoe, and slaves' days off at Christmas.

BAHAMAS FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Nassau
AREA	10,010 sq km (3,864 sq miles)
POPULATION	307,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	English
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Bahamian dollar

Jamaica



The third largest island of the Caribbean, Jamaica is a land of springs, rivers, waterfalls, and sandy beaches. A few wealthy families dominate the island, but the slum areas around Kingston are controlled by violent gangs. Many of the people of those areas are Rastafarians, worshippers of the former Emperor of Ethiopia. Jamaica is a prosperous country, with booming tourist, mining, and farming industries.



Cricket is a popular game.

Women

The Caribbean women's rights movement began in Jamaica, and many Jamaican women

hold senior posts in economic and political life. An increasing number of women prefer to be single mothers, especially those who have careers. Women also dominate the growing data-processing industry, largely because they work for lower wages than men.



Reggae

Jamaica's distinctive form of popular music, reggae, began in the 1960s as an offshoot of rhythm and blues, with songs calling for social and political change. Bob Marley (1945–81), whose band won world fame in the 1970s, is a reggae icon, and his birthday is celebrated by all Jamaicans.



Vegetables

Jamaicans grow a wide range of vegetables. *Dasheen*, or *taro*, is a staple vegetable whose root and leaves are eaten. There are more than 1,000 varieties of *dasheen*, and it is also used for medicinal purposes. Okra, or lady's fingers, are green pods that are used in "pepperpot stews". Breadfruit, with a creamy, pulpy texture, grow to 13 cm (5 in) wide, and are eaten baked or roasted.

JAMAICA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Kingston
AREA	10,990 sq km (4,243 sq miles)
POPULATION	2,600,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	English
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian, Rastafarian
CURRENCY	Jamaican dollar



Bauxite

Jamaica is the world's third largest producer of bauxite, the ore from which aluminium is made. Refineries produce alumina, the next stage in producing the metal, worth ten times as much as the ore. This provides about half of Jamaica's export income, and accounts for 10 per cent of global output.